

When you arrive in a new country, check in to your hotel and then head out for a stroll. Look in the shop windows, buy a city map, wander through the markets and bakeries. Stop for coffee at a pleasant café. Pay special attention to the mundane. Are the sidewalks in good repair or do you have to watch where you step? How do the locals negotiate their way through the streets, and who gives way to whom? Do people and cars obey traffic signals?

When you observe carefully you sort of exchange a bit of yourself for a bit of your temporary home. Within an hour or two you'll begin to connect with your strange surroundings.

Enjoy the new and different. Vicki's first attempt to make Turkish coffee in our rented Yugoslav apartment ended with boiled coffee grounds all over the stove. But after a couple of tries she had it down. Change your eating and sleeping patterns to accommodate the local rhythm. Instead of eating dinner at 7:00 or 8:00 P.M., like in the United States, eat when the locals eat—at 5:00 P.M., 10:00 P.M., or whenever. Get up at 6:00 A.M. or 10:00 A.M., depending on the local customs.

An American we know moved to Argentina and tried to keep his American habits. Within a few months he had developed dangerously high blood pressure, a mental block against learning Spanish, and an irritable personality. He lived in his lonely hell for about a year before he decided to convert to the local way of life. By the middle of his third year his health was excellent, he spoke Spanish well, and he was enjoying himself for the first time since the move.